STRIKING A BALANCE

A TOUGH TASKMASTER WITH A WARM CORE, LALDUHOMA WILL HAVE TO KEEP THE ZPM UNITED AS WELL AS THE BJP AT THE CENTRE HAPPY

By **KAUSHIK DEKA**

The first thing Lalduhoma did after taking oath as the Mizoram chief minister on December 8 was visit a drug rehabilitation centre. Checking drug abuse in the state was one of the top poll promises of his six-party alliance, the Zoram People's Movement (ZPM). From January to November this year, 68 people died of drug abuse in Mizoram, which has a population of just over a million. The state remains a major smuggling route for narcotic substances from Myanmar. The visit wasn't surprising given how the 1976-batch IPS officer first rose to prominence for busting drug networks in Goa. Over four decades later, at the age of 74, he is Mizoram's oldest debutant CM today.

Lalduhoma has been a man of action since his police days. Soon after his swearing-in ceremony, he announced 12 programmes that his government aims to implement in the next 100 days. He has set aside Rs 110 crore to buy ginger, turmeric, chilli and broomsticks directly from farmers, fulfilling the promise that many credit for ZPM's victory. His government will also form a monitoring panel to keep tabs on development projects. The committee will have representatives from political parties, NGOs, the Mizoram Kohhran Hruaitute Committee (a conglomerate of major churches) and the Mizoram People's Forum (MPF), a church-backed poll watchdog. On the promise of action against corruption, Lalduhoma's government will invite the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) to probe graft cases in the state, and strengthen the Lokayukta, if needed. The VIP culture has been struck down too—VIP dropping enclosures at the airport have been removed and ministers are not allowed to have huge entourages.

The CM understands that his key challenge will be to tackle the financial crisis Mizoram faces. Central assistance accounts for nearly 90 per cent of the state's revenue, and fiscal deficit in the previous financial year was 7 per cent of the GSDP, twice what was estimated in the budget. That's perhaps why Lalduhoma, who has taken the finance portfolio, has asked people not to expect major



LALDUHOMA, 74

PERSONAL BACKGROUND Born into a farming family in Tualpui village in Mizoram

EDUCATION: Graduated from Gauhati University; became an IPS officer in 1976

FAMILY: Is the youngest of four siblings, and has two sons

POLITICAL TRAINING: Was part of several outfits before he floated his own party that merged with the ZPM in 2017

POSTS HELD: Was in the security service of former PM Indira Gandhi; elected as an MP and MLA later

WORK STYLE: Is known to have a tough public demeanour, though his colleagues say he is very jovial personally